

# The AI Shake-Up

As ChatGPT use declines, students turn to faster growing tools such as Gemini, Claude to better suit academic needs

Sitting at her desk at home, Justine Maria Uribe Estrada struggles with a math problem. Instead of using an AI platform like ChatGPT and mindlessly getting an answer, she opens Claude to collaborate with the platform and further her learning.

Uribe's seems to be one of many people moving away from using ChatGPT. By October 2025, ChatGPT downloads decreased by more than 8% globally, and Americans were spending significantly less time on the app, with the average time dropping 22.2% since July 2025.

Gemini, one of ChatGPT's competitors, has seen the opposite trend. By March 2026, the number of monthly Gemini users increased from 450 million in mid-2025 to more than 750 million, making it the fastest-growing AI platform.

The number of Claude users is also increasing, but to a lesser extent. In early 2026, there were about 2 million users. By the end of 2025, that number had reached more than 20 million users and continues to rise.

This decline in ChatGPT users and increase in the use of other AI platforms is also seen at Palo Alto High School. In an informal survey of 20 students, seven said they currently use ChatGPT, compared with nine who use Gemini and 10 who use Claude.

Uribe Estrada said she has been using Claude for more than a year, primarily for her computer science work.

"I started using Claude after Sonnet 3.5 was released, around October 2024," Uribe Estrada said. "I switched away from ChatGPT because it's a better model overall and has better coding capabilities, which is what I mainly use it for."

Senior Amanda Tormada said she also prefers Claude because of its clarity and customization.

"I use Claude primarily because I've customized it significantly such that it provides me with incredibly honest, blunt responses," Tormada said. "It has grown to become my favorite AI tool for this customizability."

Uribe Estrada also said Claude has a sidebar that displays results in real time. For example, if she asks Claude to program a game, the chatbot can show the working game in the sidebar alongside the conversation.

"I like Claude better than other AI platforms because of Claude Artifacts," Uribe Estrada said. "They are code, documents and interactive web apps that Claude makes that give you a visualization of your conversation, instead of you having to scroll through a wall of text."

Tormada also said she noticed differences between

the quality of ChatGPT's responses and Claude's.

"I was a bit late to the ChatGPT craze, so I began using it for non-school-related things in early 2025," Tormada said. "But fast, I discovered Claude, and its [user interface] was far more appealing to me than that of ChatGPT. The quality of responses also differed, and still differs, from ChatGPT's quality, and I find that Claude can be more reliable for the things I use it for."

Computer science teacher Christopher Bell said his students primarily use Gemini because the district has a deal with Google.

"For students, we have to use Gemini in class if it's something that I send them to do in class because of data privacy," Bell said. "We have no agreement with Google, but every other platform doesn't really have that sort of educational agreement."

Bell said he personally uses both Claude and Gemini, but rarely uses ChatGPT.

"I really like Gemini's NotebookLM," Bell said. "It will just take material that I've already created and work from those instead of getting everything online."

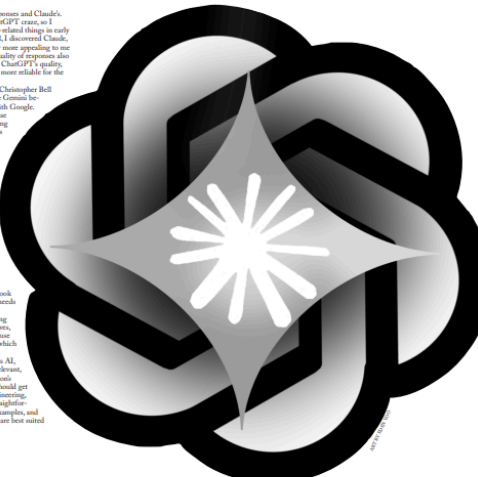
But all the different models are easy enough to pick up once you've got one, so then I just look for whether it is meeting my needs in a fast enough fashion."

Tormada said AI is becoming more important in students' lives, and they should learn how to use it responsibly and how which platforms work best for them.

"I believe that as we move AI, but I also believe it is a very relevant, very cool factor in our generations' lives," Tormada said. "People should get comfortable with prompt engineering, which I found to be pretty straightforward once I saw a couple of examples, and determining which platforms are best suited for which tasks."

Alex Chun

Lifestyle & Tech Editor



## As creatine gains popularity, students weigh benefits, risks

As senior Ismael Lee wraps up his late-night gym workout, he grabs his shaker bottle and pours inside his most essential ingredients: vanilla-flavored protein powder, creatine water, a dash of cinnamon and finally, five grams of creatine monohydrate.

As creatine gains in popularity, many students, including Lee, have made it a part of their routine at the gym. Lee said he started to use creatine at age 17 when he heard about its variety of benefits.

"I've always read the benefits of it online, through social media, and I figured if I'm consistently working out in the gym, I figured it could help me at least build muscle," Lee said.

According to Mayo Clinic, creatine is a compound made in the body from amino acids, which are the building blocks of protein. Stored mostly in muscle, creatine helps regenerate ATP, the body's quick energy source. These extra ATP then elevate the body's endurance and performance during bursts of activity.

According to Ismael Murthy, junior and co-president of the Poly Sports Lifestyle Club, creatine is primarily used for its function in recovery after working out.

The main reason why a lot of bodybuilders use it is because it helps them recover their muscles a little faster," Murthy said. "And then I think it also helps with water retention and muscles and things like that. And that's how overall muscle size can increase with it."

Murthy said creatine can also reduce discomfort and harm after working out.

"There are some studies that suggest creatine may reduce the occurrence of muscle cramps, strains and other musculoskeletal injuries," Murthy said. "It helps reduce inflammation after intense training sessions."

Murthy said creatine also has benefits beyond improving physical well-being.

New studies have come out that creatine is also positively linked to neural function and cognition," Murthy said.

After talking to his grade, Lee said he saw the results he desired after taking creatine.

"After taking it for a while, I felt like my muscles were much more filled out," Lee said. "You could definitely feel the difference, and more water, I was definitely bigger."

Despite these benefits, athletic trainer Justine Long said creatine does have potential risks, especially for athletes.

The biggest concern [of risk] was out in high school, but when I worked at the collegiate level, Long said. "A lot of operators in track use creatine, but if they don't drink enough water, they end up pulling their muscles while they do their sprint workouts."

The reason for this, Long said, comes down to what creatine does inside the body.

Creatine can dehydrate and cause you to pull muscles because you have to drink a ton of water in proportion to how much creatine you're taking and the intensity of your normal training," Long said.

In addition to dehydration, Lee said he noticed other side effects of creatine that led him to stop taking it.

"I felt like I was bloated because personally I didn't drink enough water, so I could definitely feel the effects more than if I drank a lot more water,"



500 grams of creatine monohydrate from Nutracost performance sit on a table among other supplements. Justine Ismael Murthy said creatine is useful for improving performance. "Creatine is one of the most studied supplements," Murthy said. "It's safe for people to use — teens and adults. It's just a supplement, not a drug or anything — it's naturally found in different foods, like meats, so it's the same idea as supplemental protein powder but you're supplementing something else."

Lee said. Despite these side effects, Lee said taking creatine was worth it. "The only negative thing I can think of is not being bloated," Lee said. "But again, that's kind of on me, because I didn't drink enough water."

Murthy said while goals for individuals vary for the gym, people can view creatine as a safe and useful supplement for improved performance.

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Editor's note: This article is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Students should consult with a doctor, registered dietitian or a qualified healthcare professional before starting any new supplement.

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This is the page that me and my partner designed from the latest cycle, so it shows my most recent work. This shows growth as this was the first semester where I was tasked with designing a page as I did not work on a publication before. I had to learn all of the different requirements for these pages such as specific pica spacing and I believe that I am now better at page design than I was at the start of the semester. However, I think that I can still get better with more experience.